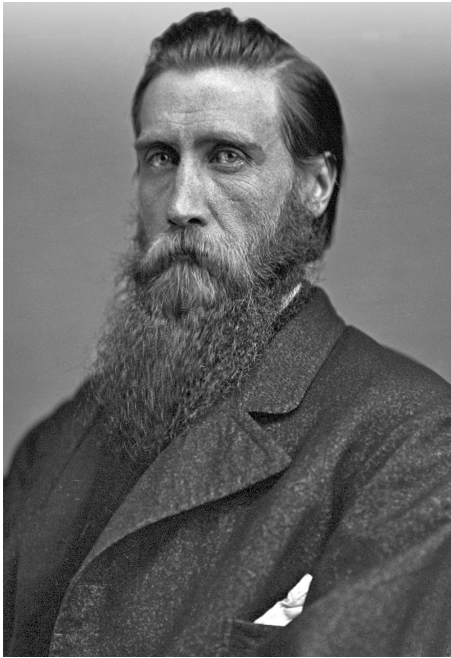


CONFEDERATE GENERAL (1831-79)

JOHN BELL HOOD



"All lion, none of the fox," tawny-maned John Bell Hood was a soldier of unbridled aggressive instincts. Though born in Kentucky, he was a Texan by choice, and "Hood's Texas Brigade" became Robert E. Lee's favorite shock troops. Hood also made a superb divisional commander, despite losing a leg at Chickamauga and the use of an arm at Gettysburg. When he succeeded Joe Johnston in July 1864, he became, at 33, the youngest man in the war to lead a major army—perhaps a factor in the rash way he led the army to death at the battles of Atlanta and Franklin.

New leader, new tactics

Hood struck immediately. On July 20, he surged out from behind his defenses and hit a part of the Union army that was separated from the rest by steep-banked Peachtree Creek, 10 miles (16km) to the north. But the attacks were piecemeal, the onslaught costly. Union commanders reported hundreds of Confederate dead piled up before their defenses.

Undaunted, Hood wheeled to the east and two days later attacked the other half of Sherman's forces outside Decatur. Throughout the long evening of July 22, the Confederates again hurled a series of ferocious but disjointed assaults against the Union lines, and were repulsed with twice as many losses as their opponents. By the end of the night, at the Battle of Atlanta, as this engagement came to be called, a procession of wagons was rumbling into the city, carrying thousands of wounded men. On July 28, Sherman moved west around Atlanta's defenses, trying to reach the Macon & Western Railroad, the city's southern lifeline. Hood